

ONCD calls for public input on ways to strengthen OSS security

The Office of the National Cyber Director (ONCD) in the US has announced a call for public input on a strategy to fortify open source software (OSS) security. Teaming up with key players in the cybersecurity and technology fields, the ONCD's request for information (RFI) seeks to harness collective expertise in order to bolster the resilience and safety of open source software systems.



Scheduled to close on October 9, the RFI, a collaborative effort involving the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA), the National Science Foundation (NSF), the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), and the Office of Management and Budget (OMB), marks a significant step towards addressing the mounting security concerns surrounding open source software.

The impetus behind the RFI derives from the commitment outlined in the American National Cybersecurity Strategy. This strategy, a White House initiative, emphasises the need "to invest in the development of secure software, including memory-safe languages and software development techniques, frameworks, and testing tools."

Highlighting the broader implications of securing open source software, the RFI underscores its pivotal role in national security, economics, and technological innovation. As open source software finds itself deeply embedded across federal agencies and critical infrastructure, vulnerabilities within these components can propagate widespread and potentially damaging effects.

With a clear awareness of the benefits and vulnerabilities of open source software, the RFI envisions a concerted effort to elevate open source software to a national public priority.

Through the current RFI, ONCD, CISA, NSF, DARPA, and OMB aspire to pinpoint areas that deserve government attention, as well as to address critical queries such as mitigating systemic risks, ensuring the sustainability of open source communities, and devising technical and resource-based solutions for OSS security.

Türkiye unveils OSS initiative for tech advancement and cybersecurity

Türkiye has unveiled an ambitious open source software initiative aimed at revolutionising its public institutions. This strategic step, initiated by a decree signed by President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, underscores the nation's commitment to technological advancement and cybersecurity.



The initiative's primary objective is to tap into the potential of open source solutions, fostering cost savings in IT

expenditures, reducing dependence on external software vendors, and fortifying cybersecurity measures. The move aligns with a global trend recognising the pivotal role of open source software in promoting innovation and ensuring digital sovereignty.

Under this new roadmap, all public institutions are expected to integrate open source software. Failure to comply will require institutions to provide explanations, highlighting the gravity of the initiative. To facilitate this transition, a template has been established by the Presidency's Digital Transformation Office, requiring relevant institutions to submit their transition plans within nine months.

The software sector's representatives, backed by the Software Council of the Union of Chambers and Commodity Exchanges of Türkiye (TOBB), have been advocating for the adoption of open source software. This move not only opens significant market opportunities for domestic software companies but also eliminates the burden of chronic software licensing payments within the public sector.

Türkiye aims to prioritise open source alternatives over commercially licensed software for goods and services procurement, except in cases of technical or economic infeasibility. This approach aligns with the nation's commitment to self-reliance and security.

The move mirrors efforts by other nations to safeguard their interests in the digital realm. Notably, the United States has launched its open source software initiative to counter the influence of Chinese companies in the telecommunications sector.

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